AEDIFICARE
EDITION 10
GB/Z 177-2026

THE GRADE

China put an IQ grade on every phone and laptop.
Then it wired the grade to the till.

October 20.
Beijing.
One number.

Xie Cun, spokesman for the Ministry of Industry and Information Technology, took a question at the State Council press office. More than one hundred AI devices, he said, now meet the requirements of L3.

Phones. Laptops. Televisions. Glasses. Car cockpits. He called them assistants, able to read a complex intent and act before being asked.

Nobody in the room asked what an L3 is. Everybody already knew. That is the story.

L1	Response
L2	Tool
L3	Assistant
L4	TBD

GB/Z 177-2026 went live on 8 May. Three ministries signed it: industry, commerce, market regulation. Seven product classes sat the first exam, from handsets to car cockpits to earbuds.

L4 has a name, Collaborative. It has no test. The mobile standard marks its requirements TBD.

This is not a driving level.

SAE levels divide who is liable when a car crashes. This ladder scores what a device can finish on its own.

L3 means the phone asks a follow-up when the brief is thin, splits the task, calls the right apps, and remembers you between tasks. Pass mark: 80 percent success across typical scenarios.

The model does not sit the exam. The phone does. Model, operating system, apps and permissions, marked as one candidate.

66

Products certified L3 in the first batch. 17 July 2026, World AI Conference, Shanghai. Seventeen companies. The standard was ten weeks old.

42

were Lenovo.

37 laptops and desktops. 3 phones. 2 tablets. Of the 66, 41 were computers and 9 were televisions. Nine were phones. One pair of glasses. One speaker.

The most certified intelligent object in China is a ThinkPad.

Lenovo helped write the exam.

People's Daily records it. Lenovo began drafting an AI PC standard in 2023, turned it into a group standard in 2024, and folded that work into the national series.

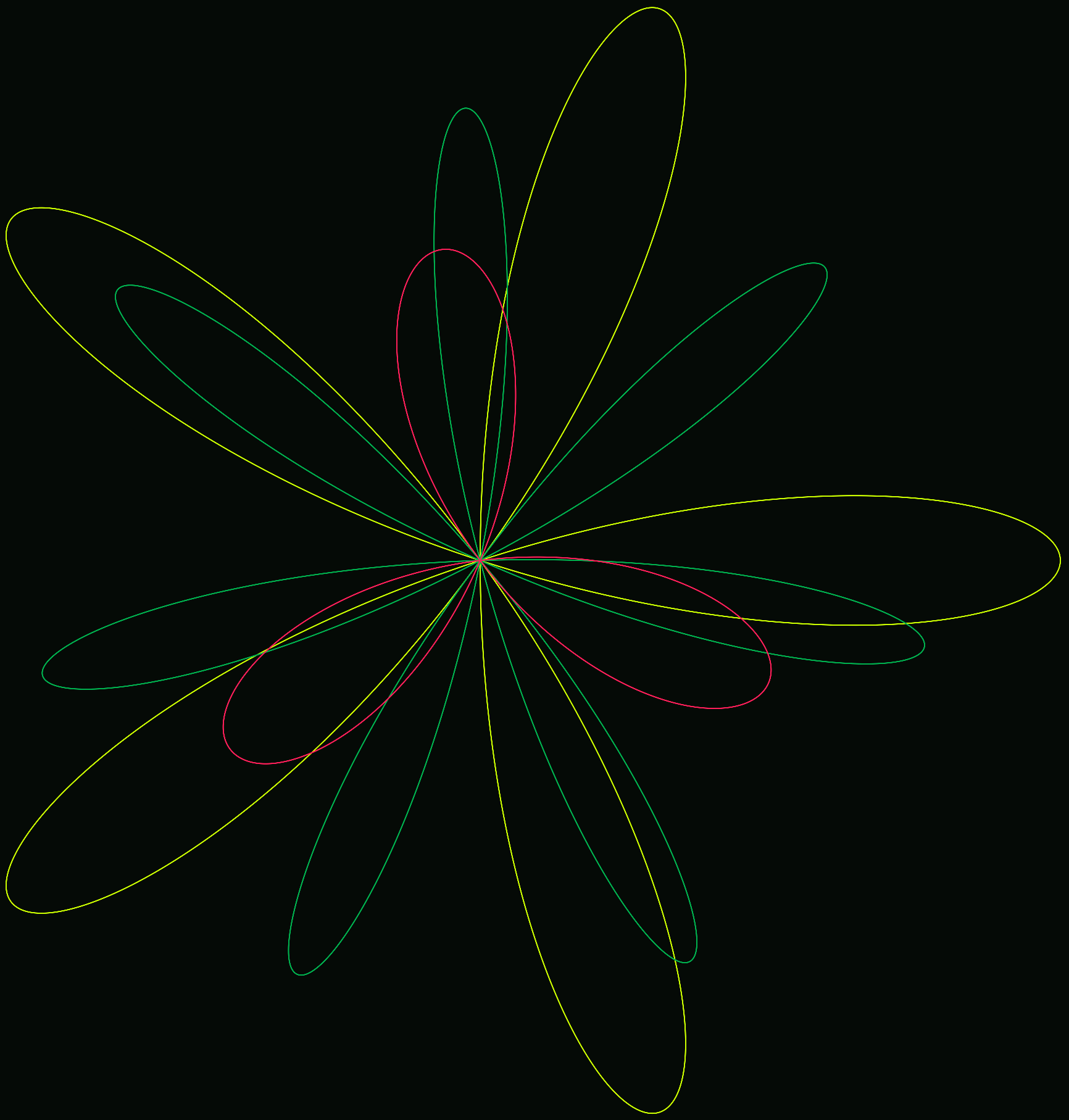
The first batch was not a survey of the market. Makers chose to submit, and chose which devices. Certificates attach to one model on one software build.

The 42 is a measure of readiness, not of the market.

The soft parts are judged by hand.

Speech accuracy and generation speed have numbers. Emotion perception, health perception and complex reasoning do not. They run as scenario tests, and a professional decides whether the result is reasonable.

A standards explainer published in August says it plainly: a device can clear every hard metric, land flat on the soft ones, and still take the grade.



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AEDIFICARE
EDITION 10
2026.10.22

The grade is a door.

On 8 May, the day the standard launched, the ministry listed its third task. Carry the standard into the 2026 consumer trade-in programme. Build a catalogue of AI terminal products to guide what the public buys.

The 2026 trade-in policy answers in kind. Subsidy categories are to be set with reference to the grading standard and to grade certification.

Call it the Catalogue.

15% off. 500 yuan cap.

Phones, tablets, watches and glasses under 6,000 yuan. Computers inside the appliance scheme. One item per person per class, paid by the state.

On 19 October, MIIT's Wei Wei said the trade-in channel would be used to speed adoption of AI computers and phones.

A certificate is a line in the Catalogue. A line in the Catalogue is a share of that money.

The press release is the advert.

18 July. Huawei claimed the first certificate. Xiaomi claimed national level. vivo called L3 the highest rating available. OriginOS followed the next day.

StepFun's STEPX Neo, a first-batch phone, went on sale on 16 October at 3,999 yuan with twelve months of model credits bundled. The ministry's own progress note named it.

No lab benchmark has ever sold a handset. A certificate from the state does.

100 000 000

Smart terminals shipped in China in the first half of 2026, by MIIT's count. The ministry expects AI devices to outsell non-AI devices this year for the first time.

In July a second batch of standards opened: wrist wearables, learning tablets, smart toys, whiteboards, projectors, industrial computers, lighting, robot vacuums, smart locks, translation pens.

The ladder is being bolted to every socket in the house.

Most of what China owns is L1.

At the launch, CESI's Yu Xiuming said the devices people hold are generally L1 and L2. Some new products reach L3.

The distance between the grade in your pocket and the grade in the Catalogue is the replacement cycle. It was drawn by a label, not by a chip.

The West grades risk. China graded ability.

The EU AI Act sorts systems by harm. Washington has no label at all. In the West, AI PC means whatever a chip vendor's NPU floor says it means.

Beijing wrote a capability ladder, had the makers help write it, let them pick their exam day, judged the hard parts with numbers and the soft parts by eye, and wired the top rung to the till.

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EDITION 10
2026.10.22

Define the agent. Then subsidise it.

That is the order of operations. The state said what an assistant is before the market settled it, and attached a price.

Everyone in the first batch sells a certificate now. In twelve months they will sell a higher grade. L4 is still a blank line in the standard. The Catalogue decides when it fills.

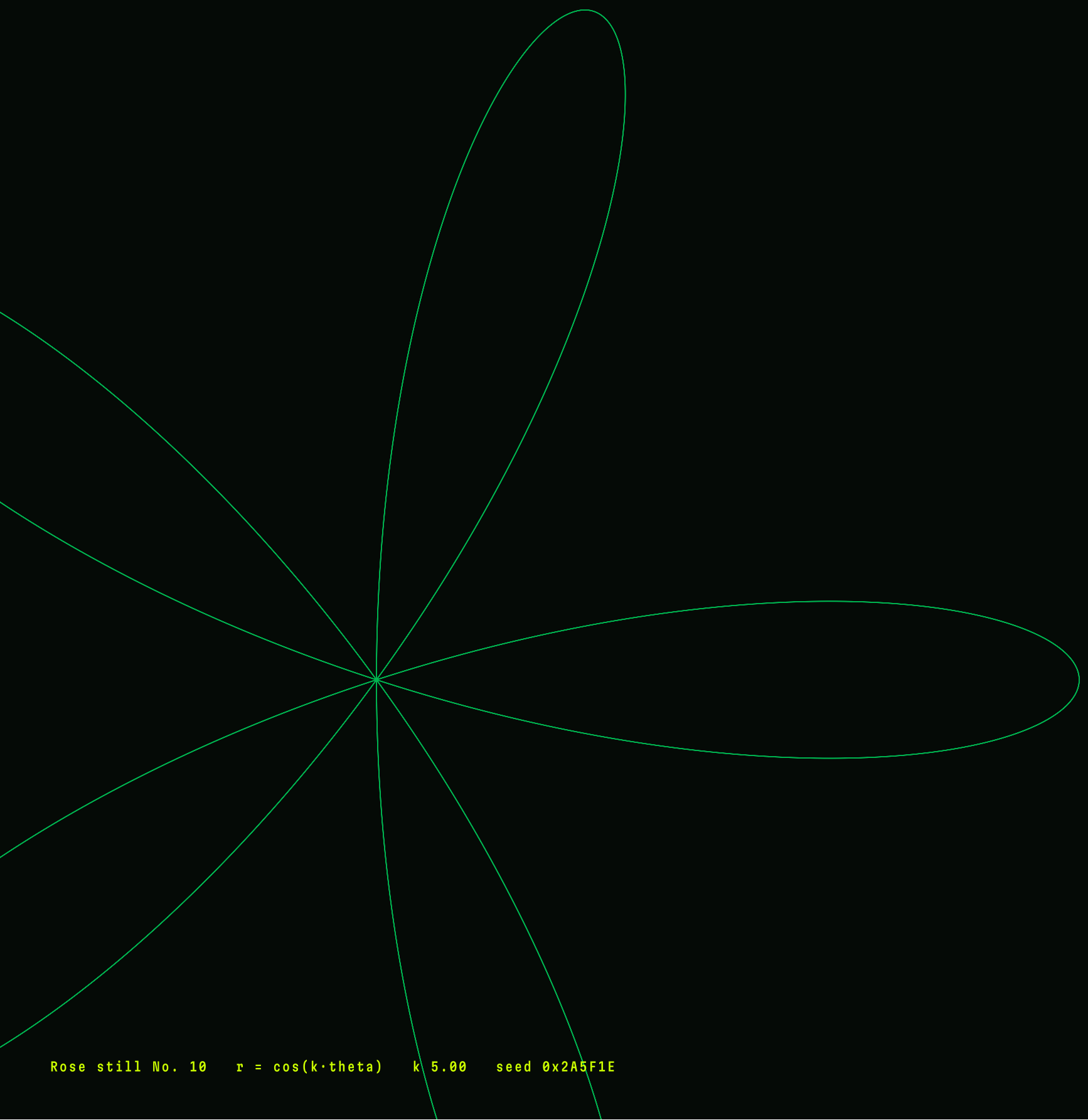
Sources.

2026.04.30	Standardization Administration of China	GB/Z 177.1–2026 Reference framework; GB/Z 177.2–2026 General requirements. std.samr.gov.cn
2026.05.09	People's Daily (Overseas)	Series launched 8 May by MIIT, MOFCOM, SAMR. Lenovo's 2023 pre-research and 2024 group standard folded into the series
2026.05.09	Science and Technology Daily via Xinhua	CESI's Yu Xiuming: high-ownership devices are generally L1 and L2
2026.05.12	Xinhua / People's Posts and Telecom News	Launch meeting, Vice Minister Xiong Jijun. Task three: trade-in implementation and an AI terminal product catalogue
2026.07.17	The Paper (Pengpai)	CAICT's Ao Li announces first batch: 66 products, 17 companies, L3
2026.07.21	Sina Tech / Kuai Keji; Lenovo disclosure	Lenovo 42 of 66: 37 PCs, 3 phones, 2 tablets. Category split 41 PCs, 11 mobile, 9 TVs, 3 cockpits, 1 glasses, 1 speaker
2026.08.06	Geek Park via Huxiu and 36Kr	GB/Z is a guiding technical document, not mandatory. 80 percent pass mark. GB/Z 177.3–2026 marks L4 TBD. Vendor claims of 18 to 19 July
2026.08	Standards explainer (Sohu)	Soft metrics run as scenario tests judged reasonable by professionals
2026.10.12	Pingwest	2026 trade-in policy: subsidy categories set with reference to the grading standard and grade certification
2026.10.13	QbitAI; Jiemian; IT Home	STEPX Neo Pioneer Edition, 3,999 yuan full-stack price, twelve-month credit plan, on sale 16 October
2026.10.19	China Electronics News; SCIO briefing	MIIT's Wei Wei: 100+ products at L3; 100 million terminals shipped H1; trade-in channel for AI PCs and phones
2026.10.20	Beijing News; Southern Metropolis Daily; Sina	MIIT spokesman Xie Cun at SCIO: 100+ L3 products across phones, PCs, TVs, glasses, cockpits, earbuds
2025.12	NDRC 2026 consumer trade-in terms, as reported	15 percent subsidy, 500 yuan cap, items under 6,000 yuan; computers in the appliance scheme
Prior English	CGTN 05.08; Trivium China 05.14; Caixin Global 07.18	Launch and first batch only. No English coverage found of the October count, the Lenovo share, or the subsidy link

Figures as published. Counts conflict in one secondary source (63 L3); the three testing bodies and Lenovo both state 66. No L4 test exists at time of writing.

The Grade.

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